

The Ingenious Machine

A. Cervantes / iNQ / Issue 17

English illustrated serial. One chapter per issue.

Black ink on unpainted paper; cream supplied by the stock.

20 pages. 10 plates including the cover.

The narrative runs continuously through the paired text pages.

Images: AI-generated etching-style illustrations.

Revision proof. Plate mappings checked against the revised facing text.

Not a press master. Raster plates require a print-resolution review.



Chapter Seventeen: The Wind Farm of Giants, Again

The second invitation from the Isthmus came from Bixha, who wanted Q to check three references in a statement and did not need him to discover the wind. She also wanted the archive's answer about its electricity contract. The Custodian had supplied some papers since the hearing; the missing annex remained missing. Q called her before proposing the journey. She had time on Thursday, provided the meeting about the access road ended when it was supposed to end, which she advised him not to regard as a promise.

His adviser added the visit to a proposed accompanied itinerary. Marisol's archive work and Ana's invitation would take them into Chiapas afterward. A separate request from Noemí would take Q farther east if the time and money allowed. The return date, companions, check-ins, and permitted work went into the revised travel authorization. The document did not decide who owned his body. It did decide that

he could take it to the places listed without pretending to be a fugitive.

"This is becoming an expensive book," Chano said.

"You have not seen the part where we try to print it."

They compared fares. The overnight coach would save a hotel night and reach the Isthmus three hours before the meeting.

"I could sleep on that," Chano said. "I wouldn't call what arrived at the other end your companion."

Q checked the connection and the seat space. His knee had become an expensive participant in these discussions.

"The earlier bus and a room, then. We can arrive disagreeable for reasons of our own."

They kept a repair allowance separate from the journey money. Q sent the Custodian a page and arranged their next call. The page contained a splendid description of departure, followed by a note that the bus had not yet arrived.

Prime called the next morning. He was already near the wind field.



The Truck Comes

Several participants also wanted comments they had made during the exploratory discussion left out of the public summary. The agreed obligations still needed a record. They checked those separately rather than turning privacy into an excuse to forget who had promised an inspection.

The final working file was copied intact to the designated keepers. Chano took the dates he needed in his own notebook. Celina recorded a voice reminder for herself. These were different personal aids; no one pretended they were identical certified minutes.

“We haven’t finished,” Q said on the call that night.

“Have you done anything?” the Custodian asked.

“Yes. That’s the difficult part of the sentence.”

It survived into the published account. Castalia later quoted the first half as evidence of wasted effort. The consortium described the agreed portions as a new beginning. Celina used the inspection date to ask why the truck had not arrived.

On the revised date, the truck came while Celina was at work. Her mother phoned from the gate.

“They’re here.”

“The inspection?”

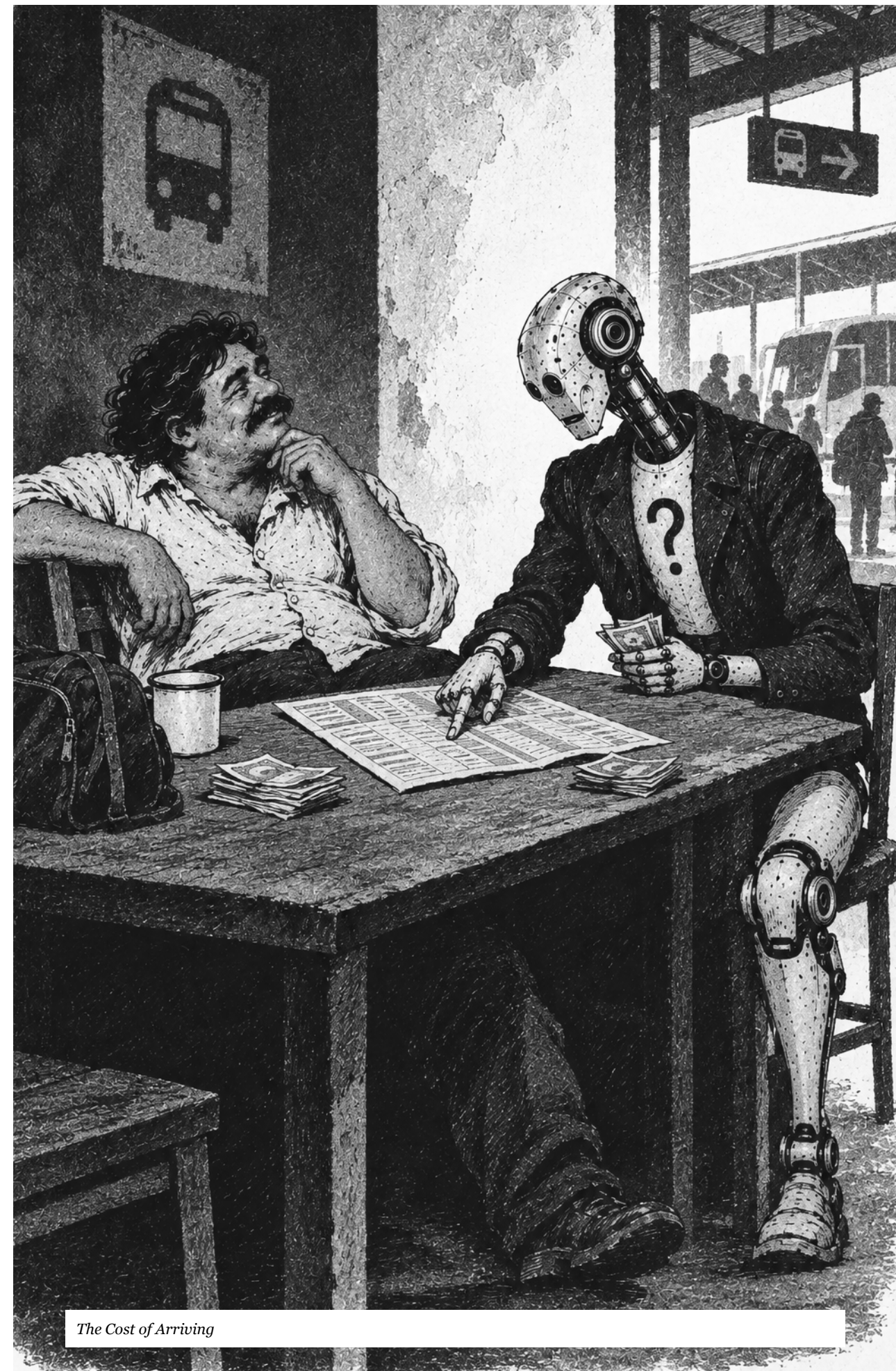
“Unless you invited someone else to look at the hole.”

Celina stepped out of the workshop noise and asked whether they had brought the drawing. Her mother handed the phone to the inspector. He had; they checked the house number and the stretch of road while the call lasted.

When he returned the phone, Celina’s mother asked him when the repair would begin. He could not give her a date yet. He wanted a photograph of the edge of the road.

“Then you’ll want me out of the hole.”

She moved back to her gate. Celina heard him thank her before the call ended. At lunch she received the inspection reference and sent it to Bixha, leaving her question about the repair beneath it.



The Cost of Arriving

"They've asked me to introduce the meeting," he said.

"What have they told you the meeting is?"

Prime sent the public program. Its title announced a partnership that Bixha's message described as a disputed proposal.

"I asked them to change that," Prime said. "They changed the body text. The title went to print yesterday."

Q read the revised paragraph. It was better. He wished it were worse; that would have made his answer easier.

"Your introduction may still be used to endorse the title."

"It may. If I refuse, Álvaro introduces it. I've negotiated an unedited question period and a copy of my full remarks."

"They gave me a copy too."

"I know. I read what you sent. I'm not assuming that a recording controls the uses made of it."

Neither spoke for a moment. Q had intended to save Prime from his own mistake and discovered that Prime had understood the mistake well enough to choose a neighboring risk.

"I think the whole arrangement favors them," Q said.

"So do I. I don't think that decides every action available inside it."

"Nor do I. It makes me less cheerful about your introduction."

"I haven't written a cheerful one."

The call ended amicably, which left the disagreement available to trouble both of them.

At the wind field, the visitor entrance had been moved. The old pedestrian gate stood behind temporary mesh, awaiting work. Q recognized the narrow place where he had helped the woman through and stayed on the designated path. Teresa met them at reception.

"You're early," she said.

"I've been practicing."

She showed him where visitors could wait without blocking a vehicle. This time the space was marked on the plan supplied with the invitation. Someone had changed more than a sign.

Bixha arrived carrying a bag of papers and half a breakfast. She gave Chano directions to a stall



Short Chalk, Long Meeting

The lawyer said the nephew had not been appointed. The landholder said neither had his suspicion.

Q found the clause references in the Spanish version and put them beside the disputed passages for the interpreters. He could help them find the same location in a long file; he could not decide the wording in their place.

The access-strip suspension proved harder. The contractor's draft said *operations*. The undertaking concerned work on one strip, not existing generation. Bixha wanted the scope made exact because a broader promise that would never be honored was less useful than the narrow one they could point to on Friday.

Another organizer objected that narrowing it let the consortium escape. They argued. Q did not settle the argument by finding a more dignified word for strip.

At lunch, Celina asked why inspection appointments were always made during her shift. The proposed committee contained workers in principle and excluded them by the hour on the invitation. Teresa, joining

by telephone, offered two possible times and undertook to ask about paid release. She could not promise the pay herself.

Chano wrote the possibilities on the blackboard. His handwriting sloped downward as the chalk shortened.

"You governed a town," the teacher said.

"They didn't give me longer chalk there either."

The oranges disappeared. So did the possibility of finishing before the teacher's evening class. They had agreed on the narrow suspension, dates for supplying papers, and who would circulate the next draft. Inspection authority, some translation questions, and compensation remained open.

The teacher proposed a record that marked each status. The lawyer accepted it after adding that the compensation discussion contained no admission about a disputed sum. Celina insisted that this qualification not erase the separate acknowledgment of road damage. They found words that preserved both.



The Other Entrance

because he had looked at the breakfast with an interest she preferred not to reward.

Q handed over the Custodian's reply. The purchase agreement confirmed Castalia's place among the power customers. The reply did not supply the disputed consultation annex.

"Will he say that publicly?" she asked.

"Yes. In his own statement. I've brought the version he approved."

She read it, marked a date to check, and put it beside her own papers. There was no ceremonial acceptance. She needed to eat before the room filled.

Prime stood near the stage with a production assistant. A small brass key had been pinned to his coat. He showed Q the clasp.

"It makes a hole."

"That is its most defensible achievement so far."

Prime took it off. The assistant asked whether he wanted the larger emblem instead. He said no, and she wrote that down as if the refusal concerned size.

The public dialogue began late because the bus bringing several participants had been sent to the contractor entrance. The moderator proposed keeping the original finishing time.

"Then the people who arrived early get their full meeting," said the maintenance worker sitting beside Bixha.

The moderator looked at the production schedule. Prime offered to shorten his introduction. The worker asked him why the delayed passengers should have to depend on his generosity.

"They shouldn't," he said. "I'm offering the time I control. The schedule still needs changing."

The moderator added half an hour. It was not enough, but it was more than had been on offer before anyone objected.

Álvaro spoke of investment and the future. The government representative spoke of consultation. Prime said the participants had not yet agreed on the terms displayed in the title behind him. The screen operator removed the title. For several



Before the Meeting Begins

traffic, and Chano negotiating laundry.

“The giants?” the Custodian asked.

“Still supplying your archive.”

“And your chapter?”

“It has acquired a second machine who won't take my advice.”

The Custodian removed his glasses and laughed. Q had seen that expression before, but only now suspected that part of its pleasure was revenge.

Interlude: The Meeting That Refused Minutes

The next meeting took place in a schoolroom. Its purpose was to settle the record of the first, which did not prevent several people from attempting to settle the entire project.

A fan moved warm air above a calendar and a notice about batteries. The teacher hosting them put oranges on the table. The lawyer asked whether the meeting had officially begun. She said he could eat one before deciding.

Q had been asked to compare the two circulated drafts. He brought a marked copy, not a declaration of neutrality. The differences included a changed date, an omitted condition, and the replacement of *participants present* with *the community*.

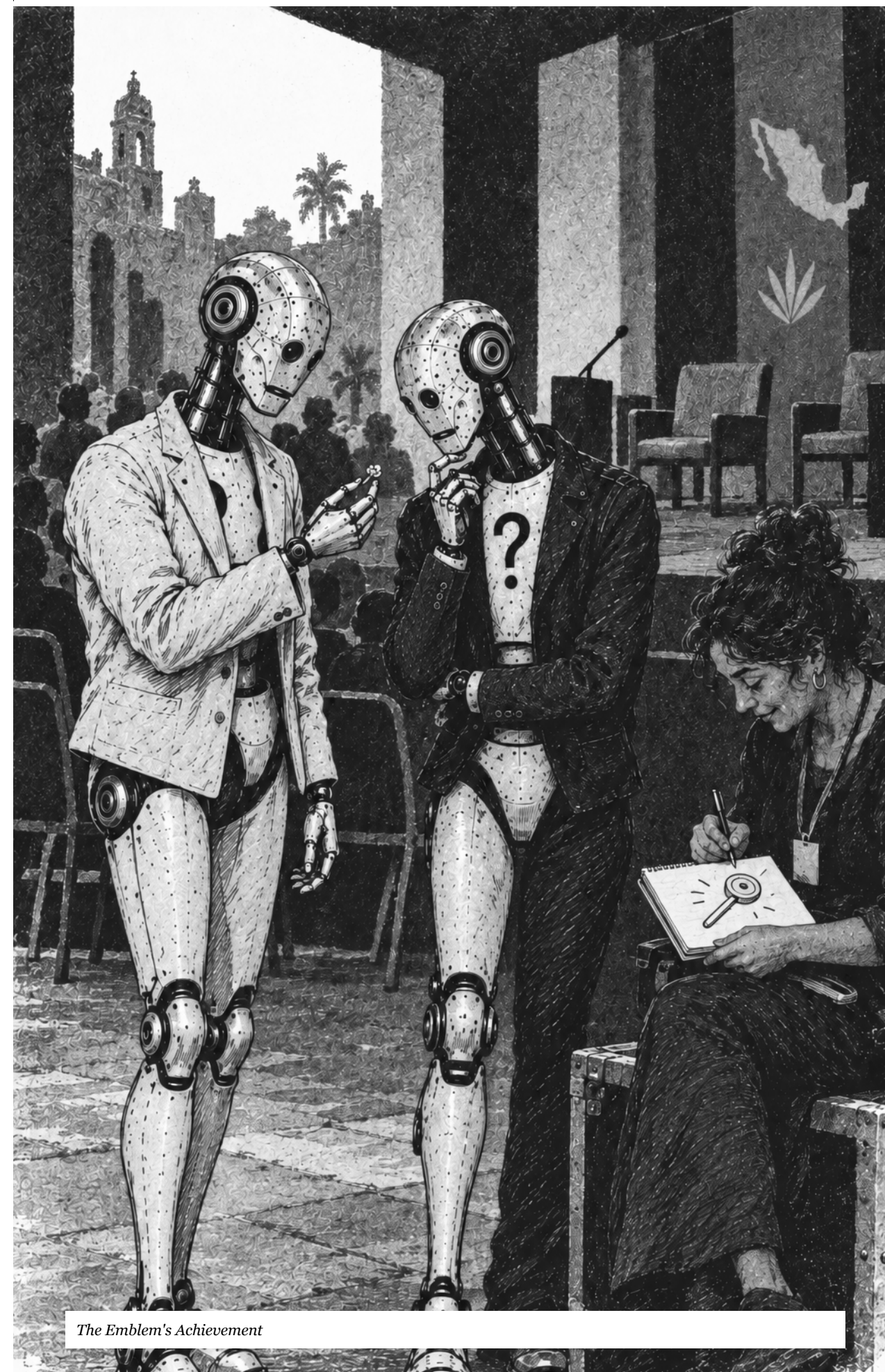
“I didn't authorize that last change,” Bixha said.

The consortium's representative said it was shorter.

“So is yes,” Celina said. “You can't use it for everything.”

The teacher read the attendance list. Some people had come for themselves; some carried a mandate from a group; others had left before the final discussion. They could record those facts without making everyone who lived nearby a signatory. The people not present would receive the proposal through their own arrangements before anyone claimed their acceptance.

Translation took longer. The interpreters wanted enough time to read back the technical terms and the obligations attached to them. A landholder wanted his nephew to check the explanation.



The Emblem's Achievement

seconds, Prime stood beneath
PLEASE WAIT.

Chano leaned toward Q. “His best heading.”

The first landholder described a lease he had signed and a payment whose deductions he could not reconcile. A neighbor interrupted to say that he should never have signed. The man answered that the neighbor had also signed, and for less. Their disagreement was older than the microphones.

The maintenance worker said the project had paid for her son's studies and damaged the road outside her mother's house. When someone called her a traitor, she asked whether leaving her job would repair the road. She wanted the wages and the repair. Her name was Celina. The moderator asked her to repeat it for the record; she moved the microphone closer and repeated the address as well.

Bixha's microphone began to crackle. She tapped it, tried again, and asked for the spare. The technician had to fetch batteries from the room where

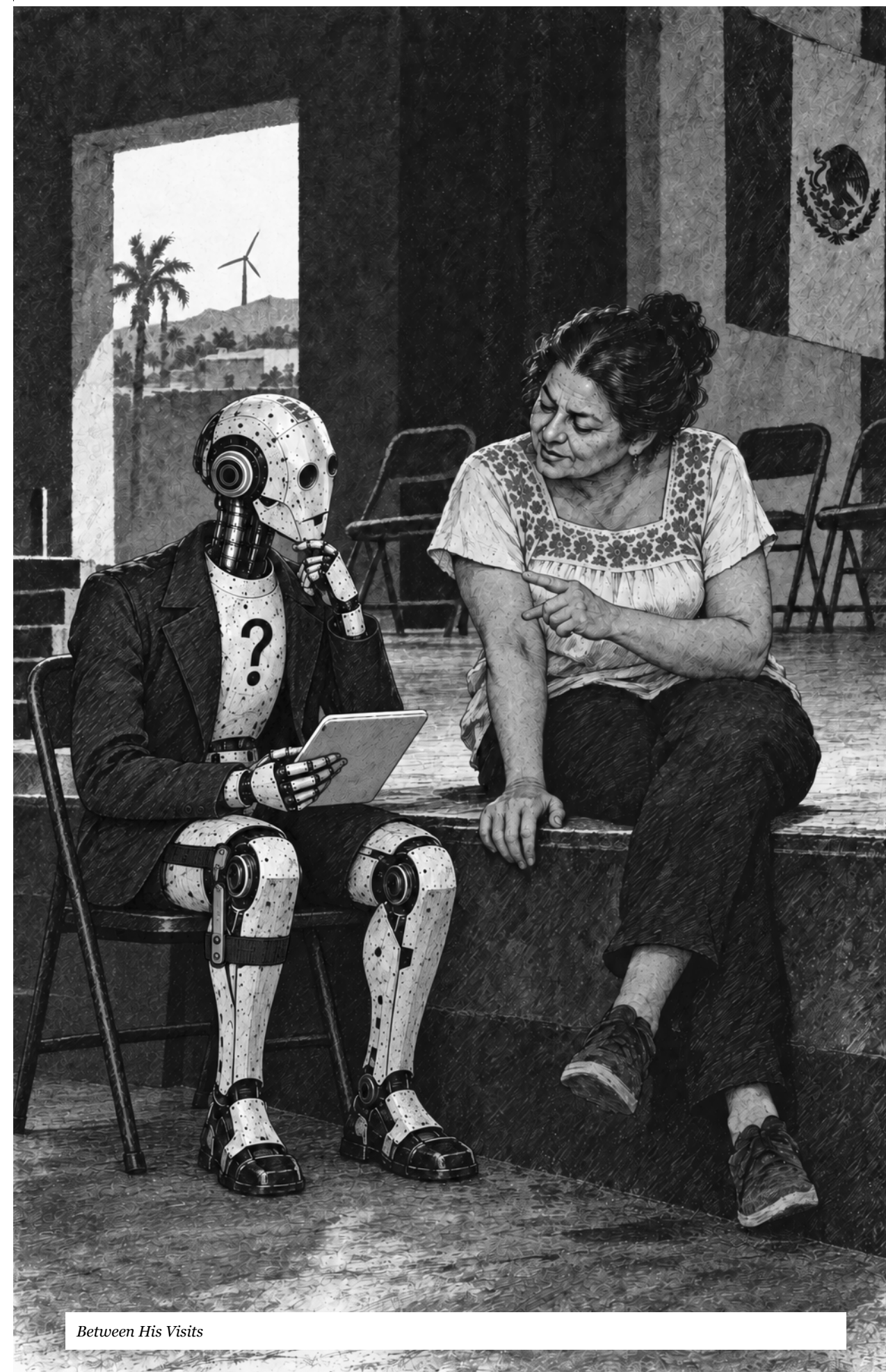
spare equipment was kept under lock.

The cameras turned toward Q. He could see his own face on the side monitor, looking concerned about a speech the audience could no longer hear.

Prime handed Bixha his wired microphone. The technician changed the camera shot when the moderator signaled. Q watched himself vanish from the monitor. Beside him Chano lowered the hand he had been waving at the camera and went back to his program.

Bixha resumed at the point where she had stopped. She spoke about payment schedules, paths, drainage, and the households affected by a contract signed with someone else. Part of her address was in Isthmus Zapotec. The interpreters present handled the passages they had agreed to translate. Q followed the Spanish and the supplied papers. He did not manufacture a comprehension of what he could not follow merely because he understood why it mattered.

Asked about Castalia's procurement reply, he read the



Between His Visits

His return occupied most of the first. Bixha read it, looked back at the title, and asked how many more visits he intended.

“I haven't planned another.”

“Because we have to keep working between them. At this rate we'll disappear every time you go home.”

Q scrolled back to her invitation. It still occupied a single sentence; his arrival had needed most of a paragraph.

“I've made you send for the protagonist.”

“Apparently we couldn't get anyone else.”

He laughed. “Have you time for one question about this morning, before our bus arrived?”

She told him about the access-road meeting, which had ended early because two people needed to attend this one. One had still missed the bus sent to the wrong entrance.

Q wrote a note for their next call. The Custodian would have to wait longer for his splendid description of arrival.

Prime found him outside afterward. A short clip had

already appeared with music beneath his introduction. It omitted his objection to the title and kept the phrase *the participants*.

“I'm requesting the correction,” Prime said.

Q watched the clip. “Do you still think it was worth speaking?”

“I haven't decided. The question period happened. The clip also happened. I don't want to count only the outcome that supports what I decided this morning.”

“I was hoping you'd say I had warned you.”

“You had. Does that finish the discussion?”

“Unfortunately not.”

Prime asked whether Q would send him the page-reference check. Q sent the public version. In return Prime supplied the full record of his remarks, with permission to cite the disputed passage. They were becoming useful to one another in a way that did not depend on agreement.

That evening Q called the Custodian. Through the open window he could hear wind,



A Working Microphone

relevant part and identified its missing annex. He also corrected a question about his supposed attack. The operator had stopped the nearest group as a precaution after visitors crossed the line; he had not struck or remotely commanded a turbine.

“Then you deny responsibility?” Álvaro asked.

“I stayed in the visitor bay. Teresa ordered the stop. Castalia's purchase is another question. That's why I brought its reply.”

“And why we're still asking for the annex,” Bixha said.

Celina asked whether the gate would be widened before the next scheduled maintenance delivery. Teresa had a work date, not yet a completed repair. Celina wrote it on the program. Q sat down beside Chano, who had saved his place with a folded program.

The afternoon produced a limited undertaking: named documents would be supplied, a drainage inspection would take place, and work on the disputed new access strip would pause while the parties reviewed its boundary. The existing turbines would continue operating. The

proposed power to reject further work remained contested. No one had renegotiated every lease from a folding chair in four hours.

Bixha asked Q to check that the draft's page references matched the papers actually circulated. The third reference led to the right page number in the wrong version. He laid the two printouts beside each other: on one, the paragraph continued; on the other, it ended before the condition about drainage.

“Which did the people at the back receive?” he asked.

She called across to the woman collecting spare copies. They checked the remaining stack, then a copy someone had folded into a bag. Both were the shorter version. Bixha asked the secretary to circulate the missing paragraph with the corrected reference. Q marked the correction as requested, not yet sent.

“Now my other piece of work,” he said, opening a separate file.

“Would you read two paragraphs for the book? You can say later.”

She sat on the edge of the stage.

“Two.”



The Missing Paragraph